

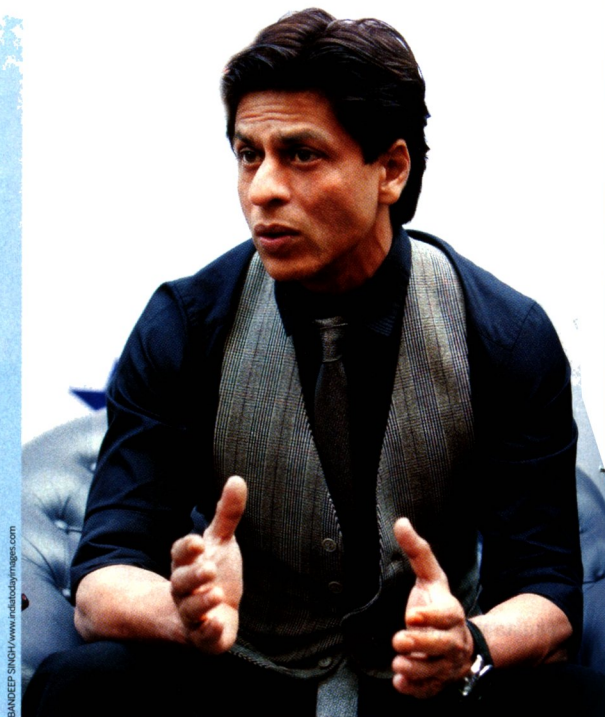
Interview | **SHAH RUKH KHAN**

"I feel like a madman whom no one trusts"

*It's almost 1.45 in the morning. Shah Rukh Khan has just finished teaching his son, who has an exam the next day. As he settles down to watch the game between AC Milan and Manchester United, his favourite football team, his thoughts are as chaotic as the last fortnight has been, ever since his comment that Pakistani players should have been picked to play in the IPL. His sense of humour remains intact as does his understanding that the critical and commercial success of *My Name is Khan* is not a moment for him to gloat over. Instead it's a time to feel great humility, as he says to Executive Editor KAVEREE BAMZAI in a two-hour long conversation, for the extraordinary support from everyone on what he feels was an unfortunate and "complete waste of time for the entire nation".*

Q. Was there ever a moment of self-doubt in this long and difficult fortnight?

A. I've become what I am because of the city of Mumbai. So of course I was sad that I couldn't release *My Name is Khan* here. But as I've grown older, I've lost my mom's aggression and developed my dad's patience. I've tried to look at it philosophically. I asked my son what he thought and he said if you've done nothing wrong, then let it be. And that's what I've done. Let go. I've always prided myself on being articulate and now I think this may have taught me to be quiet, to speak my mind only on matters that concern me. You know it's come to such a pass that now when I go out, my wife Gauri asks me, "Where are you going? Is the media there? If it is, don't speak." I'm hosting an awards show, and can you imagine she says she will okay the script? She says no one understands my sense of humour. I feel like I'm one of those mad people whom no one trusts. I feel my sanity is being questioned by those closest to me and that my family will soon begin to be embarrassed by me. The other



day Karan Johar came home for dinner, and said to me, "Bhai, can I tell you something? For the next few days, please shut the f*** up." Ours is not a political film but I think the politics around it became too big for us to understand.

Q. Did you ever feel you should retract what you said?

A. But what is there to retract? I've met Balasaheb and Uddhav Thackeray but I've never had ideological discussions with them. With due respect, I think they overreacted. But no apology was asked of me. No one called me and told me to do so. After a time I just gave up. I thought if *My Name is Khan* doesn't release, it doesn't. I told my partners Karan and Fox Star Studios, I would make up for the losses. But while fully respecting Balasaheb and Uddhav's agenda, I genuinely felt the misconception could have been cleared. I don't think anyone realised its repercussions. It wasn't a level playing field. I am not a politician. They are not filmmakers.

Q. Why did you say it?

A. I was asked a question on a TV show, "Why are Pakistani players not in the IPL?" My logic was, and is, that there is an issue. Yes, there is a paradox. On one hand, we get angry when a former Pakistani air chief's picture is used in a Government advertisement. On the other, there's an emotional outcry when

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